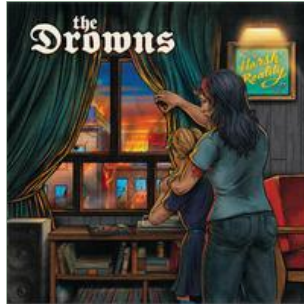


The Silver Lining by Paul Silver



THE DROWNS – Harsh Reality (Pirates Press Records, thedrowns.bandcamp.com)

It's been fascinating following the career of The Drowns. From their 2018 debut, *View from the Bottom*, to today, they've evolved their sound, played around with genres, and gotten tighter and tighter. They've released excellent street punk records, they've toyed with classic rock, they've put out super-fun glam, and they've record some incredible power pop. On this outing, the band brings us a mix that includes 90's melodic punk, street punk, and more.



Guitarist/vocalist Rev writes about half the songs, and he favors the bold street punk and glam sounds. The album opens strongly with one of these, "Always a Bastard," Rev's gritty voice shouting the lyrics as the high energy music plays behind him. The guitar lines have a cool, lonesome sound to them, and the rhythm section pounds relentlessly. "Relentless" and "'Let's Start a Cult'" are solid street punk tunes, the former with big sing-along gang vocals in the chorus. One of the most fun and unique Rev tunes is "3rd & Pike," an upbeat mix of glam and Zydeco music, complete with accordion, but with dark lyrics about broken trust. Another good one is the hard-driving "Vengeance," which mixes glam, hard rock, and street punk.

Andy Wylie's songs tend to be smoother, more focused on power pop and melodic punk sounds. "Have a Heart" has a cool bounce, with a dark melodic punk vibe. "Hellish Tattoo" and "Strangled Voices," too, have a solid 90's melodic punk sound, with parts that are dark and parts that are bright and poppy. Andy's vocals sometimes verge on crooning, too, reminding me a little bit of Josh Caterer's vocals with The Smoking Popes. Speaking of which, my favorite Andy song of the album has to be "Burn the Page," which oozes poppy music and crooning vocals, bouncy and bright, but with lyrics about the terrible state of the world today. "Death of the Optimist" sees a bit of Rev's street punk vibe seeping into Andy's pop punk tune, particularly in the chorus.

Although it's pretty easy to tell the difference between songs written by Rev or Andy, one thing they all have in common is their unrelenting energy. Every Drowns song comes across as an unstoppable force. The boys from Seattle have another winner on their hands.



GOODNIGHT NOBODY (Sweet Cheetah Records, goodnightnobody.bandcamp.com)

Debut albums are always fun. Discovering new music from new bands you've never heard of before can sometimes be like hitting the lottery. Goodnight Nobody is a trio that hails from Vermont and plays edgy, noisy indie that injects mathish moments, emo influence, and a bit of punch into their music, and this is their debut LP. I can hear the grit of dissonance, twisted rhythms, and melodic hooks,

sometimes sounding like a descendant of Dischord Revolution Summer bands, sometimes sounding more like a 90's post-hardcore band. The opening track falls into the latter category, with grinding guitars and fuzz-filled bass. Vocals are emphatically shouted as the beat pulses hypnotically, as the band jams. "(We've Got the) Receipts" is a strong mix of strident post hardcore chords and emo melodic lines and vocals. "Can vs. Should" is another that features both melodic indie/emo, but also a jamming bridge that goes hard



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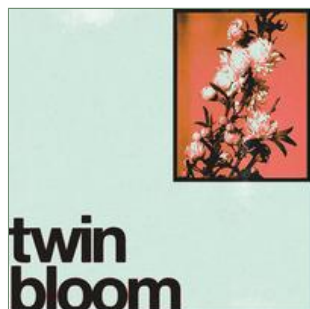


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jumping cautionary tale of addiction and its severe consequences. *Enigma* is an interesting document, and another example of important figures in punk stretching the boundaries of their music. It's a nice listen, but I do wish there was a little more variation in textures among the songs.

**SUNDAYCLUB (Paper Bag Records,
paperbagrecords.com)**

Winnipeg may best be known as the home of the NHL's Winnipeg Jets, but the South Central Canadian city is also home to a thriving music scene. It is the birthplace of major performers such as The Guess Who, Neil Young, The Crash Test Dummies, and Bachman-Turner Overdrive. And it's also the home of a bustling indie scene. One of these bands is sundayclub, the duo of vocalist Courtney Carmichael and multi-instrumentalist Nikki St. Pierre. Forming in 2019, after meeting while attending university, they're finally releasing their debut LP. And if you look up "dream pop" in the dictionary, you'll find a photo of the two of them, along with a link to listen to their music. The tracks on this LP are hazy and reverb-drenched, filled with bright pop melodies, melancholy instrumentals, and introspective vocals. Listening to songs like "Blue Wave," you could be listening to major pop artists, except the arrangement here is much more complex than arena bubblegum pop, much more sweeping and epic in sound. Carmichael's vocals are gorgeous, silky smooth, and the instrumentals are lush and, well dreamy. "Blue Wave" soars uncontrollably, and is a real stand-out. "Camera Shy," too, has a melody worthy of any of a number of top pop artists of today. But it's the more atmospheric songs that I like best. Songs like "Tune In," which opens the album, are simply otherworldly. And "Sober" is really like something out of a dream, light and ethereal. sundayclub's debut LP is lovely stuff.



**TWIN BLOOM (Dandy Boy Records,
twinbloom.bandcamp.com)**

Most dream pop is lush, thick, and melancholy, but Oakland's Twin Bloom mixes a sparer 80's aesthetic into its brand of dream pop, giving it a slightly brighter and more upbeat feel. It's not like this record is sparkly sunshine stuff; compared to, say, typical indie pop, it's thick and lush and a bit morose. But by dream pop standards, this is downright jangly and happy. So Twin Bloom's music fits nicely somewhere between those two extremes.

On this debut, self-titled EP, we get four songs of bouncy dream pop, which is normally an oxymoron. It's nice stuff, particularly "Magazine Dreams," a song that could have been a radio hit in 1983. I just wish the recording quality was a little better. It's like listening to a bedroom demo, with compressed and clipped frequency bands and more noise than I'd like.

**FUSES – Sawdust in the Transmission
(Having Fun Records,
bandetfuses.bandcamp.com)**

Fuses is a trans-Atlantic duo featuring drummer/bassist Moa-Linn Rosenlöf (from Gothenburg, Sweden) and Guitarist Craig Fahner (from Toronto and New York). The pair met when Fahner's band, Motorists, played some shows in Sweden. This meeting turned into a creative collaboration, with song ideas sent back and forth across the sea. They finally reconnected in person to record this debut LP at a Swedish recording studio with ties to Sweden's 1970s "political prog" movement, and once the recordings were completed they were in a courthouse getting married. The music on this LP is soft and relaxed, with lovely folk-rock jangle blended with down-home country twang, and featuring lush vocal harmonies. The opening track and lead single, "Garden of Ashes," features acoustic guitar and steel pedal guitar providing a Fairport Convention like listening experience. Tracks like "Vemod" feature a relaxing blend of prog rock and folk rock, with a soft and soothing vibe, complex guitar riffs, ambient keyboards, and occasional harmonica. And songs like "Idle Heart" have a curious blend of country, honkytonk, and spiritual music. Sometimes things drag a bit. "Floor is Lava" feels a little too slow, and I feel it would be



improved with a slightly brisker tempo and a bit more energy. The closing track, "Bakom Molnen," even though it also has a slow pace, is a great slow burner, with some bluesy guitar licks. Sawdust in the Transmission is a nice hazy, lazy debut for fans of relaxed folk rock and Americana.



JULEZ AND THE ROLLERZ – Dirty Little Rock 'n' Roller (Lolipop Records, julezandtherollerz.bandcamp.com)

Julez and the Rollerz is the project of Jules Batterman, an LA musician that sings and plays guitar on this debut LP, along with friends Shea Carothers (keyboards, vocals), Morgun Payge (bass, vocals), and Sarah Park (AKA Spark, drums). The band plays a particularly Los Angeles brand of power pop that's polished with glam and glitz, ready-made for clubbing in Hollywood. Mixing the

rock 'n' roll grit of progenitors The Runaways (Joan Jett is even a stated inspiration) with 70's glam rock and 80's new wave kitsch (thanks to the atmospheric synths,) Julez and the Rollerz offer up nearly 30 minutes of retro-rock good-time party music that will transport you back to a previous generation, while still sounding rooted in today's aesthetic. The music is poppy without sounding sappy and silly, with just enough rock and roll power. The songs are energetic and upbeat, designed to take your mind off the troubles of the world instead of constantly reminding you of them. I like the new wave-inspired, angular riffs in "Phaser," and I enjoy the jazzy rhythms of "Call Me Up." "Hot Take" is the song that gives the album its title, with self-aware references to "LA musicians posturing as reincarnated 70's rock stars" and tongue-in-cheek pokes at the ego that goes along with that persona. It's also easily the edgiest track of the album, the most down and dirty crawling out of the gutter rock and roll song of the LP. But the best track of the album, in my opinion, is "Always Hard 4 U," a song that channels 90's indie pop of the sort that was made by bands like Tsunami or Velocity Girl back in the day. Julez and the Rollerz' earlier material (they've previously released an EP and some singles) focused more on grittier garage rock like that, along with lilting indie-pop, and I think there's more personality in those songs than most of what's on the LP. While some of the songs are pretty good, I think they're playing it too safe with the polish on this LP.

MANTAROCHEN – "Wellness Ward" EP (It's Eleven Records, itselevenrecords.bandcamp.com)

Leipzig, Germany's Mantarochen has released a slew of singles, an EP, and an LP in their short existence. Their latest effort is a five-song EP of their icy cold-wave music, with frigid goth-like guitars and blasé vocals. The instrumentals are a bit dreamy, but the lead vocals are problematic. Maybe it's purposeful, but they're off key and a little too relaxed, almost somnambulant. The singing is often in a different key than what the guitar and bass are playing, and it gets painful at times. This was hard to listen to.



JR. JUGGERNAUT – "Firecracker (Fourth of July)" (Nickel Eye Records, jrjuggernaut.bandcamp.com)

Bridging the gap between last year's critically praised LP, *Another Big Explosion*, and a new LP they plan to record later this summer, LA's Jr. Juggernaut decided to release this new standalone single just in time for Independence Day. For those who aren't aware, Jr. Juggernaut is a long-standing LA institution, playing melodic indie rock, with power pop melodies and grunge-influenced grit,

resulting in songs that echo latter day Hüsker Dü. Frontman Mike Williamson's vocals even sound a bit like Bob Mould's, with a full sound and just a hint of gruffness. On this new single, there's a hint of blues in the guitar riffs, but overall there's a distinct early 90s indie vibe, with a bold summer sound. Williamson's vocals are stronger and more heartfelt than ever, and, as always, it's hard to believe they're just a trio, because the instrumentals sound so thick. This is the way to start the summer!

GRAHAM PARKER & THE GOLDENTOPS – Quality Footwear: Live at the Brook (Big Stir Records, bigstirrecords.bandcamp.com)